

There is a universal experience that unites all human beings. No, not paying taxes. Not accidentally liking a photo from 2018 while stalking someone's Instagram. And definitely not pretending to understand what's happening in a family WhatsApp group. It's wanting to be chosen. Honestly, if we're being real, we've been competing to be chosen since nursery school. "Teacher! Teacher! Look at me!" Then primary school came and suddenly the games teacher was choosing football teams. Some of us discovered two things that day. One, we couldn't play football. Two, rejection builds character. Nothing humbles you quite like standing there while everyone else gets picked, and you're trying to convince yourself you actually preferred being the referee anyway. You stand there with your hands in your pockets, pretending to be deeply interested in a blade of grass, praying that your name gets called before the groups dwindle down to the final three people who are clearly only being inherited by default. It is the first time we learn to build a defense mechanism. We laugh it off, we make a joke, we say we didn't want to play anyway, but the small, quiet part of your brain marks that moment. It learns to brace itself.

That is the exact moment we begin calculating our value based on someone else's clipboard. We tell ourselves that if we just run faster, smile wider, or become completely indispensable, we won't ever have to stand on that baseline again. We start curating our existence before we even know who we are, operating under the silent, heavy assumption that our default state isn't quite enough to make someone stop and point at us first.

Then we grow up. Except... we don't. The games teacher simply changes. Now it's companies choosing candidates. Friends choosing who sits next to them. Someone choosing whose story they'll reply to first. Your favorite aunt choosing which cousin gets an extra piece of nyama at the family gathering. We all know that cousin. If you don't, congratulations. It's probably you. We play the same games, we just use different platforms. We post a carefully curated photo on our status, not for the two hundred people who will view it, but for the one specific person whose name we are waiting to see pop up in the viewer list. We check the views like we're auditing corporate tax returns, looking for that one digital nod that says, "I see you." We pretend we're above it, but we are all secretly keeping score of who holds the door open for us and who lets it slam in our face.

It's an exhausting digital ledger we keep in our heads. We look at a text that was left on delivered for three hours and we don't just see a busy schedule; we see a hierarchy where we've been placed at the bottom. We analyze the brevity of a reply, the absence of an exclamation mark, the sudden lack of warmth, treating these minor shifts like tectonic plates moving beneath our feet. We live in a constant state of performance, terrified that the moment

we stop being interesting, or funny, or useful, the audience will quietly get up and leave the theater.

The older I get, the more I realize life is simply a series of tiny moments where we're quietly asking the same question. "Would you choose me?" Not because you have to. Because you want to. That's the important part. There's a Kenyan saying that if someone wants to find you, they'll find you. Somehow, people can navigate Nairobi traffic, survive Ngong Road at 5 p.m., and still make it to KICC for an event they actually care about. Funny how impossible distance becomes when the destination matters. We all know the sheer, unadulterated horror of Ngong Road when the rain starts at dusk and the matatus begin driving on the pavement. It is an Olympic sport of human misery. If someone braves that gridlock, gets rained on, and arrives at your door smelling like damp air and diesel exhaust just to spend forty minutes with you before they have to turn around and do it all over again, that isn't convenience. That is a loud, unspoken declaration. They didn't come because they had nothing better to do; they came because everywhere else felt like the wrong place to be.

Because convenience is a cheap currency. Anyone can show up when the weather is good, the roads are clear, and it aligns perfectly with their schedule. But intention is expensive. Intention means someone looked at the absolute chaos of their day, looked at their own exhaustion, and decided that your presence was worth the friction it took to get there. It's the realization that you are not an afterthought or an entry on a checklist; you are the priority that reconfigures the rest of their world.

Maybe people are a little like that too. Being chosen has very little to do with convenience. It has everything to do with intention. You know you've been chosen when someone remembers you without needing a reminder. When they're buying smokies and suddenly think, "Sharon likes these." When they save you a seat in church. When they send you a meme that made them laugh because, somehow, your happiness crossed their mind before they even opened WhatsApp. Those moments look ridiculously ordinary. Until you're the one receiving them. Then suddenly they're priceless. They are priceless because they require no performance. You don't have to be wearing your best outfit or speaking in your most intelligent, professional voice for someone to think of you when they see a funny street sign or a specific brand of chocolate. It's the realization that you exist in their mind even when you aren't standing in front of them. You are a permanent resident in their thoughts, not a temporary visitor who has to keep knocking on the door to remind them that you're still outside.

There is a quiet profoundness in realizing you occupy space in someone's mind when they are entirely occupied by the world. It means that while they are navigating the noise of their own life, your existence is a constant, gentle hum in the background. They aren't choosing you

because you are performing for them in that exact moment; they are choosing you because the memory of you is enough to bring them peace in the middle of their own noise.

Because here's the funny thing about human beings. We'll say we don't need anyone. Then our favorite person says, "I got home safely." And somehow... the entire day gets better. We're funny creatures. We want independence. But we also want someone to notice when we've gone unusually quiet. We want freedom. But we secretly hope someone notices when we're missing. We're walking contradictions. We build these massive, impenetrable walls of independence, loudly proclaiming to anyone who will listen that we are perfectly content being single, entirely self-sufficient, and emotionally bulletproof. We go to cafes alone, we pay our own bills, we handle our own crises. But the moment that one specific person notices the slight, three-second hesitation in our voice over a phone call and asks, "Is everything okay? You sound different," the whole fortress crumbles. We don't actually want to be alone; we just want to know that if we disappear into the dark, someone cares enough to bring a flashlight.

It's the terrifying vulnerability of being perceived. For years, you convince yourself that your strength lies in your ability to hide your fractures. You become an expert at smiling through the anxiety, at saying "I'm fine" with the perfect, practiced cadence of someone who has it all figured out. But true safety isn't someone admiring your walls; it's someone looking at the fortress you built and gently saying, *"You can come out now. The war is over, and you don't have to fight me to keep your dignity."*

Maybe that's why rejection hurts more than we admit. It isn't always because we lost someone. Sometimes it's because we wanted to know that, in a world with eight billion people, someone looked around and thought... "You." Not the loudest person. Not the funniest. Not the richest. You. We spend so much of our lives trying to optimize ourselves. We go to the gym, we study for degrees, we learn how to hold eye contact, and we practice being witty, all under the assumption that if we become the most polished version of ourselves, someone will finally pick us. But the most beautiful kind of being chosen is when you are completely unpolished, when you are tired, grumpy, overthinking, and making absolutely no sense, and they look past the chaos, past the presentation, and point directly at your messy soul.

They choose you when you are defensive. They choose you when your pride is flaring up and you are actively trying to push them away because your old ghosts are telling you that safety is a trap. That is the kind of being chosen that fractures your old logic. It is one thing to be loved when you are easy to love, when you are pouring warmth into their hands and making everything seamless. It is a completely different, breath-stealing thing to be chosen when you are complicated, guarded, and convinced that you are too much trouble to keep around.

Maybe that's what we've been searching for all along. Not applause. Not popularity. Simply the quiet comfort of knowing that somewhere, someone keeps choosing us on purpose. And perhaps the greatest gift we can give another person isn't expensive presents or elaborate speeches. Maybe it's letting them rest in the certainty that they never have to wonder whether they matter. It is the luxury of a closed case. No more investigating clues, no more wondering if a delayed reply means they are losing interest, and no more bracing your body for the inevitable impact of them leaving. You finally get to put down the heavy, exhausting luggage of having to earn your place in their life. You just unpack your things, sit down on the couch, and breathe in the quiet, terrifyingly beautiful knowledge that you are already home.

And in that quietness, your nervous system finally begins to slow down. The hyper-vigilance that used to keep you awake at night starts to feel irrelevant. You stop looking for double meanings in their sentences; you stop translating their silence as a threat. You realize that healthy love doesn't demand you break yourself into smaller, more convenient pieces just to fit through their door. You get to keep your full shape, your heavy history, and your jagged edges, because the person who chose you didn't just pick the version of you that was easy to hold, they chose the whole, unvarnished reality of who you are, and they have no intention of letting you go.